

Teaching with AI Feedback: An Experience Report on the Challenges and Takeaways from a Quasi-Experimental Study

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Abstract

This experience report presents qualitative findings from a quasi-experimental study at Towson University examining ChatGPT's role as an evaluative partner in a junior-level business communication course. Across 15 course sections taught by five instructors, the intervention embedded AI feedback into the drafting process using rubric-based heuristics, staged integration, and reflective prompts. Post-semester faculty interviews revealed that when scaffolded intentionally, AI feedback reinforced instructor guidance, functioned as a "second reader," and supported deeper revision, rhetorical awareness, and metacognitive growth—particularly among engaged students. However, instructors also reported uneven engagement, limited feedback literacy, and instances of misuse when students treated AI as a generative shortcut rather than a revision partner. These findings underscore the need for pedagogical guardrails, early integration, and explicit instruction in evaluative prompting. The study positions AI not as a replacement for human feedback but as part of a multi-voiced feedback ecosystem, blending machine and human perspectives to foster clarity, audience awareness, and confidence in student writing.

CCS Concepts

• Applied Computing; • Human-centered computing; • Natural language interfaces;

Keywords

AI in education, digital literacy, writing pedagogy, ChatGPT

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1 Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) tools such as ChatGPT are rapidly entering higher education, raising questions about authorship, audience, and feedback. In writing-intensive fields—especially business communication, where clarity, precision, and audience awareness are

essential—the challenge is positioning AI not as a shortcut but as a tool for revision, rhetorical awareness, and metacognitive growth.

This paper presents qualitative findings from a quasi-experimental study at Towson University in which five instructors across 15 sections of a junior-level business communication course implemented a structured AI feedback process anchored in the College's Business Writing Rubric. While the broader mixed-methods design compared instructor-only feedback with AI-supported revision, this report focuses on post-semester faculty interviews addressing three questions: (1) How did instructors perceive AI-supported revision's impact on student writing? (2) What scaffolds and conditions supported effective use? (3) What challenges and ethical concerns emerged?

Findings suggest that when guided by targeted heuristics, framed through reflection, and introduced early in drafting, AI feedback can reinforce instructor guidance, deepen revision, and prompt critical thinking about audience and purpose. Uneven engagement, varied feedback literacy, and misuse risks highlight the need for intentional scaffolding, ethical guardrails, and structured opportunities for metacognitive reflection.

2 Background and Related Work

The integration of large language models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT into writing instruction has sparked debate about their pedagogical role. While concerns about plagiarism and overreliance persist, recent scholarship examines AI as an evaluative partner that provides feedback prompting reflection, revision, and rhetorical awareness rather than replacing student writing [5], [7]. Feedback is central to writing pedagogy, but its value depends on how students interpret and apply it. Reader-response theory frames meaning-making as a transaction between writer and reader, suggesting that AI can serve as a simulated audience that draws attention to clarity, tone, and structure [1], [2]. Likewise, constructivist learning theory emphasizes active engagement, negotiation of meaning, and iterative reflection [3]; when scaffolded, AI feedback can reinforce these processes by functioning as a responsive "second reader."

This study also draws on the pedagogy–andragogy–heutagogy (PAH) continuum [5] to explain differences in student engagement with AI-supported revision. Students at the pedagogical stage rely on explicit instructor direction, those in the andragogical stage work independently within structured guidance, and those approaching heutagogy engage in self-determined learning. Faculty observed that a student's position on this continuum influenced whether AI feedback was treated as a simple correction checklist or as a prompt for deeper rhetorical thinking.



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Research on digital literacy in higher education underscores the need to teach students how to engage critically with AI-generated content, distinguishing between productive and unproductive uses [4], [6]. Without explicit guidance, students may default to generative prompting—asking AI to produce text rather than evaluate it—undermining both learning outcomes and professional writing skill development. This study contributes to this emerging body of work by exploring faculty perceptions of AI feedback's benefits, limitations, and ethical considerations in a real classroom context, offering practical recommendations for integrating AI into business communication courses.

3 Study Context and Methodology

3.1 Study Context

This experience report draws on faculty interviews from a larger quasi-experimental study in BUSX 301: Business Communications at Towson University, a required Core 9 course in the College of Business and Economics. The course serves a demographically representative cohort: 47% racially or ethnically diverse and 46% female, reflecting the university's commitment to inclusive excellence [6], [7], [8].

Across 15 sections taught by five instructors, approximately 300 students participated in a semester-long project comparing instructor-only feedback with an AI-supported revision process. The intervention used the College's Universal Business Writing Rubric and a structured ChatGPT prompt guide to evaluate drafts against rubric-based heuristics for higher-order concerns (message, organization) and lower-order concerns (style, mechanics). While the broader study included quantitative draft analysis, this report focuses solely on post-semester faculty interviews.

3.2 Participants

All five instructors from the pilot participated, representing 100% of eligible faculty. Each taught at least one control section (instructor-only feedback) and two experimental sections (AI-supported revision), providing comparative experience across conditions. All instructors had at least two years of experience teaching BUSX 301 and had received prior training on the Universal Business Writing Rubric.

3.3 Data Collection

Interviews were conducted via Zoom in Spring 2025, lasted 45–60 minutes, and were recorded with participant consent under an IRB-approved protocol (Texas Tech University Study #IRB2024-36, exempt). Exemption was granted because the study involved minimal risk and focused on instructional practices. The semi-structured protocol was developed using insights from prior scholarship on AI in writing pedagogy and aligned with the study's three guiding questions. Interview topics included:

- Implementation strategies for AI feedback.
- Observed impacts on student engagement and revision practices.
- Perceived benefits and limitations.
- Ethical considerations and potential for misuse.

3.4 Data Analysis

Recordings were transcribed verbatim. Open coding was applied to identify recurring concepts, which were iteratively refined through constant comparison into thematic categories. Two coding passes were conducted: the first to generate provisional codes, the second to merge, collapse, or refine these into broader themes. A peer familiar with the research reviewed code definitions and theme assignments; discrepancies were resolved through discussion until consensus was reached.

4 Findings from Faculty Interviews

4.1 Improved Revision and Alignment with Learning Goals

Instructors reported that students who actively engaged with AI feedback produced more rhetorically effective revisions. Four of five faculty saw “noticeable” improvement in AI-supported sections, with one noting students “did a lot better... especially as compared to the other class.” AI acted as a “second voice,” reinforcing instructor guidance and helping students prioritize revisions. When students reworked awkward sentences or removed jargon based on AI suggestions, their writing became clearer, more precise, and aligned with the course's plain-language objectives. One faculty member recalled a student replacing jargon-heavy phrases with straightforward alternatives after ChatGPT flagged them, producing “the most audience-appropriate version of their memo I'd seen all semester.”

4.2 Engagement Gaps and Strategies to Address Them

These gains were uneven. Highly motivated students experimented with revisions and asked follow-up questions, while less engaged peers found the feedback volume overwhelming, describing it as “a wall of text.” Instructors suggested earlier integration of AI feedback—such as after a first section draft—delivered in smaller segments to reduce resistance and normalize AI use as part of the process rather than a last-minute edit. Faculty also stressed the importance of structured prompts that require students to articulate why they accepted or rejected AI suggestions. This approach was seen as key to developing feedback literacy and narrowing the gap between high- and low-engagement students.

4.3 Metacognitive Growth and Rhetorical Awareness

When students engaged deeply, 3 out of the five instructors observed a shift from surface-level correction to purposeful, audience-centered revision. These students could explain the rationale for changes, signaling metacognitive growth. AI feedback also expanded their rhetorical vocabulary, enabling more precise discussion of tone, clarity, and structure. One student reflected, “By implementing the suggested changes, I'm not just refining a document, but strengthening my skills as a communicator.” Faculty identified this ability to connect feedback to rhetorical purpose as a critical step in developing professional writing competence.

4.4 Confidence and Ownership of Work

All instructors reported that alignment between AI and instructor feedback boosted student confidence, often prompting strategic rhetorical revisions such as adapting tone for a professional audience or reorganizing content for clarity. However, in two instructors' classes, these gains were less common among low-engagement students, who tended to bypass deeper reflection and make only surface changes. Without reflective components integrated into the assignment, some students moved quickly through AI feedback without considering its implications, missing opportunities for skill development.

4.5 Concerns About Misuse and Ethical Guardrails

Instructors also reported instances of misuse, most notably when students used ChatGPT to generate entire drafts that were vague, formulaic, and disconnected from earlier work. Such practices bypassed the intended focus on critical thinking, rhetorical awareness, and metacognitive reflection. Faculty stressed the need to teach the difference between evaluative prompting (e.g., "Assess my clarity and tone") and generative prompting (e.g., "Write this paragraph for me"). Suggested guardrails included requiring students to document prompts, maintain reflective logs, and provide short meta-analyses of how AI feedback was applied. These measures were seen as vital for reinforcing ethical authorship and positioning AI as a strategic learning partner rather than a shortcut.

4.6 Positioning AI in a Multi-Voiced Feedback Ecosystem

Across interviews, faculty agreed that AI is most effective when paired with instructor and peer feedback. Students often found that AI reinforced or added nuance to human comments, increasing their confidence in making revisions. Instructors viewed this triangulation of perspectives as an opportunity to strengthen audience awareness, critical thinking, and the ability to synthesize feedback from multiple sources—an essential skill in professional communication contexts.

5 Interpretation and Reflection

5.1 AI as an Evaluative Partner and Simulated Audience

Faculty interviews revealed several interconnected themes. When AI was used with deliberate scaffolding, it served as a productive evaluative partner, particularly in supporting revision and rhetorical reflection. Students who actively engaged with AI feedback often produced stronger drafts, reporting a clearer understanding of rhetorical goals and increased confidence in making stylistic and organizational improvements. Faculty noted that AI feedback frequently reinforced their own comments, provided immediate and specific responses, and created opportunities for students to treat the tool as a dialogic partner or "second reader." From a reader-response perspective, AI operated as a simulated audience, prompting students to evaluate clarity, tone, and structure in ways similar to how a human reader might interpret their work [1, 2]. This dynamic reflects the constructivist view that learning occurs

through the active negotiation of meaning, particularly when learners are prompted to reflect and revise in response to perceived audience needs [3]. However, the effectiveness of AI as an evaluative tool was closely tied to students' willingness to critically engage with the feedback. Without that engagement, suggestions were more likely to be accepted at face value rather than used as a prompt for deeper rhetorical thinking, underscoring the need to integrate reflection and rhetorical framing into AI-supported writing instruction.

5.2 Shifts Toward Process-Oriented Writing

The structured interventions in this study also appeared to help shift student perspectives from using AI primarily as a means to generate a final product toward adopting a more process-oriented approach to writing. Higher-performing students, in particular, used the tool not simply to correct surface-level issues but to rethink and reframe their work, demonstrating increased metacognitive awareness and rhetorical insight. These students began to describe their writing in terms of audience engagement, clarity, and communicative purpose—behaviors aligned with the recursive revision process central to process-based writing pedagogy and the higher levels of Bloom's Taxonomy, including analysis, evaluation, and synthesis [4]. This development is consistent with constructivist learning theory, in which learners build knowledge through reflection, interaction, and iterative engagement [3].

5.3 Engagement Gaps and the PAH Continuum

This shift, however, was less evident among students who were less engaged or unfamiliar with reflection-based revision practices. For these students, AI often functioned as a generator or checklist: a means of producing what they perceived as a "perfect" product rather than a catalyst for deeper thinking about audience, purpose, or rhetorical strategy. This pattern reflects gaps in students' positioning along the PAH continuum—pedagogy, andragogy, and heutagogy. While some moved into an andragogical space, thinking critically about their rhetorical choices, others remained in a pedagogical mode, relying on explicit direction without internalizing the reasoning behind revisions [5]. Faculty suggested that integrating structured reflection prompts and modeling effective AI use early in the writing process could help close this gap. Such scaffolding could foster process-oriented habits, increase rhetorical awareness, and support more equitable writing development across ability levels.

5.4 Limitations and the Need for Guardrails

The AI intervention created a low-stakes environment for feedback, boosting student confidence and fostering rhetorical awareness by helping them refine tone, identify jargon, and consider audience perspectives—outcomes aligned with reader-response theory [1, 2] and constructivist pedagogy [3]. As such, these benefits were uneven; students with lower motivation, limited reflection habits, or weaker digital literacy often failed to engage deeply, and some misused AI as a generative shortcut. Faculty emphasized the need for guardrails—clear heuristics, prompt documentation, and reflective checkpoints—to promote evaluative rather than generative prompting. From a PAH continuum perspective [5], students not yet in

self-directed learning modes require intentional scaffolding that integrates ethics, authorship, and process-based revision to sustain critical engagement.

6 Implications for Teaching and Research

Findings from faculty interviews indicate that when positioned as an evaluative partner within process-based pedagogy, AI can reinforce rhetorical awareness, confidence, and engagement by functioning as a “second reader” that echoes instructor feedback and offers immediate, targeted suggestions, prompting students to reconsider clarity, tone, and organization in ways consistent with reader-response theory [1], [2] and constructivist learning principles [3]. These benefits were most pronounced when AI was introduced intentionally at early drafting stages, integrated with reflective prompts, and scaffolded to help students move along the PAH continuum [5] toward greater ownership of revision. Instructors emphasized the importance of ethical guardrails to distinguish evaluative from generative prompting, recommending strategies such as prompt documentation, reflective logs, and meta-analyses to discourage overreliance on AI-generated text and to preserve critical thinking, rhetorical decision-making, and metacognitive growth—hallmarks of higher-order thinking in Bloom’s taxonomy [4]. Finally, faculty stressed that AI works best when used in concert with instructor and peer feedback, creating a multi-voiced feedback ecosystem that enables students to compare, synthesize, and apply multiple perspectives strategically, an essential skill for professional business communication.

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A Appendices

Full versions of the assignment sheet and AI guide used in this study are available in the supplemental materials at: https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1EnABiwsPq4NT-CyoS_pvvkrEPuFJDluGm?usp=drive_link